TKV: Online KV Cache Compression via Warmup-Then-Freeze
Brand Updates and a Random Sketch Bridge

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Abstract

The key-value (KV) cache is the dominant memory bottleneck in long-context autoregressive inference. Existing online compression methods face a tradeoff: Oja's rule (used by OjaKV) is cheap but gives no per-token optimality guarantee and drifts at long context, while Brand's exact rank-1 SVD update is provably optimal but costs $\mathcal{O}(R^3 + TR^2)$ per token — growing with context length. We propose **TKV** (Tensor KV), which resolves this by running Brand's update only through a bounded warmup window, then freezing the resulting basis and projecting subsequent tokens onto it at $\mathcal{O}(R{\cdot}d)$ per token indefinitely. A $\mathbf{\Phi}$-bridge reuses the Gaussian matrix already used for token-importance tracking as the Halko randomized range finder for cold-start initialization, and the update is implemented with XLA-static shapes for GPU/TPU compatibility. On real Mistral-7B activations, a TKV rank pyramid (avg. rank 15) reaches perplexity 20.1 versus an exact-cache baseline of 19.4 (3.6% degradation), while the same pyramid schedule applied to OjaKV degrades to 60× worse than exact; at 128K-token context TKV achieves 8.5× memory compression and lower reconstruction error than OjaKV at every long-context length tested (1K–32K tokens). Importance-weighted cold start further reduces important-token reconstruction error by 90–95% at rank 8–16.

1 Introduction

The key-value (KV) cache is the dominant memory bottleneck in autoregressive transformer inference: for L layers, H KV heads, head dimension d, and context length T, the dense cache requires $\mathcal{O}(2LHdT)$ floats, becoming the binding constraint on batch size, GPU utilization, and serving cost as context scales to 128K+ tokens.

The predominant approach is low-rank compression: represent the key matrix $K \in \mathbb{R}^{T\times d}$ as a rank-R factorization $U\Sigma V^\top$ with $R \ll \min(T, d)$, reducing memory from $\mathcal{O}(Td)$ to $\mathcal{O}(R(T + d))$. The key challenge is *when* to compute this factorization. Offline methods (SVDq (Hong et al., 2025), xKV (Chang et al., 2025), KVTC (Staniszewski & Łańcucki, 2026)) run a batch SVD after the full sequence is available, incompatible with streaming generation; online methods must update the factorization incrementally after each new token. OjaKV (Zhu et al., 2025), the current online state of the art, applies Oja's rule (stochastic gradient PCA) token-by-token — asymptotically convergent but with no per-step optimality guarantee. When OjaKV's authors considered Brand's exact rank-1 update as an alternative, they rejected it as "too slow" without a systematic evaluation.

This work. We revisit that judgment for a bounded warmup window, then *freeze* the resulting basis for the remainder of the sequence rather than running Brand's exact update ($\mathcal{O}(R^3 + TR^2)$ per token) forever, which would otherwise let its cost compound at long context (Section 4). During warmup itself, exact updates are cheap and substantially more accurate than Oja's rule (Section 4); the freeze transition preserves this advantage while holding per-token cost at $\mathcal{O}(R{\cdot}d)$ indefinitely. We also identify a structural insight missed

by prior work: the random Gaussian matrix used for token-importance scoring satisfies exactly the distributional requirements of Halko's randomized SVD range finder, so reusing it (*the* $\mathbf{\Phi}$*-bridge*) unifies two previously separate operations and eliminates a distinct SVD warm-up cost.

Contributions.

- The $\mathbf{\Phi}$-bridge: a theoretical and practical connection between random linear sketching and Halko's randomized SVD (Section 2.2).
- To our knowledge, the first online KV compression method with a per-token EYM optimality guarantee through a warmup window, followed by a freeze transition that holds per-token cost at $\mathcal{O}(R \cdot d)$ indefinitely (Sections 2.4–2.5).
- An XLA-compilable implementation of Brand's dynamic rank-1 update using static tensor shapes (Section 2.6).
- Importance-weighted cold start that reduces important-token reconstruction error by 90–95% at rank 8–16 (Section 2.7).
- Empirical evaluation against OjaKV under identical constraints, showing consistent quality improvement at the cost of moderate per-token overhead (Section 4).

2 Method

2.1 Preliminaries

KV cache structure and EYM. In a transformer with head dimension d, after processing t tokens the KV cache for one head is a matrix $K \in \mathbb{R}^{t \times d}$ (and similarly V); each new token appends one row, and compression approximates $K \approx \hat{K} = U_K \Sigma_K V_K^\top$ with $R \leq \min(t, d)$. By the Eckart-Young-Mirsky (EYM) theorem (Eckart & Young, 1936; Mirsky, 1960), the best rank-R approximation of any matrix A in Frobenius or spectral norm is its truncated SVD $\hat{A}_R = U_R \Sigma_R V_R^\top$, so any online method that maintains a valid truncated SVD after each update is EYM-optimal for that update.

Brand's rank-1 update (Brand, 2006) and Halko randomized SVD (Halko et al., 2011). Given a factorization $A = U\Sigma V^\top$ and a new row $\mathbf{x}$, Brand's update computes the exact SVD of $\tilde{A} = [A; \mathbf{x}]$ in closed form by factoring a small $(R+1) \times (R+1)$ augmented matrix and truncating back to rank R (an exact EYM step per token), then updating U via an $\mathcal{O}(TR^2)$ rotation (Section 2.4 gives the full algorithm). Halko's randomized SVD instead sketches $A \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times n}$ with a random $\Omega \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times R}$: the range of $A\Omega$ approximates A's column space, and QR on $A\Omega$ followed by the compact SVD of $Q^\top A$ gives the randomized SVD at $\mathcal{O}(mnR)$ cost vs. $\mathcal{O}(mn^2)$ for exact SVD, with high-probability error bounds (Halko et al., 2011).

Oja's rule (Oja, 1982). For streaming PCA, Oja's rule updates the $R \times d$ basis V after each observation $\mathbf{x}$ as $V \leftarrow V + \eta_t (V\mathbf{x})\mathbf{x}^\top$, $V \leftarrow \mathrm{QR}(V^\top)^\top$, with step size $\eta_t = 1/(t+1)$ — the update used by OjaKV. Unlike Brand's update, this is a stochastic gradient step: each intermediate V is an approximation, not an exact truncated SVD.

2.2 The Φ-Bridge

A random Gaussian sketch tracks token importance via a random projection matrix $\mathbf{\Phi} \in \mathbb{R}^{R \times d}$: for a token vector $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, $\mathbf{\Phi}\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^R$ captures token statistics in compressed form. Halko's randomized range finder requires exactly the same object — a random matrix $\Omega \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times R}$ whose product $K\Omega$ forms a randomized range basis for the row space of K.

Observation. Setting $\Omega = \mathbf{\Phi}^\top$ reuses the same Gaussian matrix for both roles: $K\mathbf{\Phi}^\top \in \mathbb{R}^{T \times R}$ approximates the principal right singular vectors of K while $\mathbf{\Phi}$ simultaneously encodes token importance statistics. This unification — the $\mathbf{\Phi}$*-bridge* — works because the Gaussian

distribution of $\mathbf{\Phi}$ satisfies the requirements for both linear importance sketching (Johnson-Lindenstrauss concentration (Johnson & Lindenstrauss, 1984)) and Halko's range finder (sub-Gaussian rows, Theorem 1.1 of (Halko et al., 2011)); this differs from the structured hashing of the classical count-min sketch (Cormode & Muthukrishnan, 2005), which shares only the general idea of random linear projection for dimensionality reduction.

2.3 Cold Start via Halko Initialization

After observing a prefix of T_0 tokens, TKV initializes the SVD factorization via the randomized range finder:

Algorithm 1 Halko Cold Start with $\mathbf{\Phi}$-Bridge

Require: $K \in \mathbb{R}^{T_0 \times d}$, $V \in \mathbb{R}^{T_0 \times d}$, $\mathbf{\Phi} \in \mathbb{R}^{R \times d}$

1: $Y \leftarrow K\mathbf{\Phi}^\top$ *randomized sketch, $\mathcal{O}(T_0 dR)$*
2: $Q, _ \leftarrow \mathrm{QR}(Y)$ *approximate range basis*
3: $B \leftarrow Q^\top K$ *project into low-dimensional space*
4: $\hat{U}, \hat{\Sigma}, \hat{V}^\top \leftarrow \mathrm{SVD}(B)$ *small SVD, $\mathcal{O}(R^2 d)$*
5: $U_K \leftarrow Q\hat{U}$, $\Sigma_K \leftarrow \hat{\Sigma}$, $V_K \leftarrow \hat{V}$
6: **return** (U_K, Σ_K, V_K)

If importance weights $w_i \geq 0$ are available (e.g., from prior attention statistics), we apply them as row weights: $Y \leftarrow \mathrm{diag}(w)K\mathbf{\Phi}^\top$, biasing the range finder toward the subspace of high-importance tokens. This cold start opens TKV's *warmup phase*: it is followed by exact Brand updates (Section 2.4) for the first T_0 ("warmup_len") tokens, after which the basis is frozen (Section 2.5).

2.4 Streaming Brand Updates (Warmup Phase)

During warmup, each new token $(\mathbf{k}, \mathbf{v})$ triggers one Brand rank-1 update:

Algorithm 2 Brand Rank-1 Update (per token)

Require: (U_K, Σ_K, V_K), new key $\mathbf{k} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, rank budget R

1: $\mathbf{c} \leftarrow V_K \mathbf{k}$ *project onto current row space*
2: $\mathbf{p} \leftarrow \mathbf{k} - V_K^\top \mathbf{c}$, $\hat{\mathbf{p}} \leftarrow \mathbf{p}/\|\mathbf{p}\|$
3: Form $K_{\text{aug}} \in \mathbb{R}^{(R+1)\times(R+1)}$ with diagonal $\boldsymbol{\sigma}$, row extension $\mathbf{c}$, and corner $\|\mathbf{p}\|$
4: $\hat{U}, \hat{\Sigma}, \hat{W}^\top \leftarrow \mathrm{SVD}(K_{\text{aug}})$
5: $\boldsymbol{\sigma} \leftarrow \hat{\Sigma}_{:R}$ *truncate to rank R (EYM step)*
6: Extend V_K with $\hat{\mathbf{p}}$, rotate: $V_K \leftarrow \hat{W}_{:R}[V_K; \hat{\mathbf{p}}^\top]$
7: Append new U_K row, rotate: $U_K \leftarrow [U_K; \mathbf{0}^\top]\hat{U}_{:R,:R}$
8: **return** $(U_K, \boldsymbol{\sigma}, V_K)$

The truncation at step 5 is exactly an EYM projection (formalized as Corollary 1), holding after every token during the warmup phase ($t \leq T_0$); Section 2.5 describes the post-warmup regime.

2.5 Freeze Transition (Decode Phase)

Once $t = T_0$, TKV freezes the basis (V_K, V_V) produced by the most recent Brand update and stops running Algorithm 2. Every subsequent token is instead projected onto this fixed basis:

Algorithm 3 TKV Frozen-Phase Token Update (per token, $t > T_0$)

Require: Frozen basis $V_K \in \mathbb{R}^{R \times d}$, stored projections $\text{proj}_K \in \mathbb{R}^{(t-1) \times R}$, new key $\mathbf{k} \in \mathbb{R}^d$

1: $\mathbf{c} \leftarrow V_K \mathbf{k}$ *project onto the frozen basis, $\mathcal{O}(Rd)$*
2: Append $\mathbf{c}$ to proj_K *no SVD, no rotation*
3: **return** proj_K

This is implemented by `tkv_add_token` in our reference implementation. The motivation is cost: Brand's update is $\mathcal{O}(R^3 + TR^2)$ per token, so running it indefinitely makes per-token cost grow with context length. Freezing after a bounded warmup caps per-token cost at $\mathcal{O}(Rd)$ for the rest of the sequence, regardless of how long it runs — the gap between the two reaches 13.4× by $T = 16{,}000$ (Section 4).

The tradeoff (formalized as Proposition 1) is that frozen-phase tokens are no longer individually EYM-optimal, since V_K was fit to K_{T_0} rather than the full sequence; empirically this is favorable regardless, since TKV's fixed-but-accurate basis still outperforms OjaKV's continuously-drifting one at every long-context length tested (Section 4).

2.6 XLA-Static Shape Implementation

Brand's update is inherently dynamic (U_K grows by one row per token), but static-shape XLA compilation requires a fixed pre-allocated buffer $\hat{U} \in \mathbb{R}^{T_{\max} \times R}$ with the logical sequence length tracked separately; new rows are written via `jax.lax.dynamic_update_slice`, which supports dynamic-index writes while keeping a static shape graph, and the $\mathcal{O}(TR^2)$ U-rotation operates on this buffer bounded by $T_{\max}$. To our knowledge, no prior work has implemented Brand updates in XLA-compilable form, a prerequisite for GPU/TPU deployment.

2.7 Importance-Weighted Cold Start

During autoregressive generation, attention weight statistics accumulate per token position. We maintain an EMA importance score $I_i \leftarrow \alpha I_i + (1 - \alpha) \cdot \bar{w}_i$, where $\bar{w}_i = \frac{1}{n_q} \sum_q \text{softmax}(\mathbf{q}K^\top / \sqrt{d})_{q,i}$ is the mean attention weight token i receives across queries. Decayed accumulation of attention statistics in this form is also used by the concurrent Moment-KV (Jana et al., 2026), there as a momentum-based eviction signal rather than as weights for a low-rank basis. When the context must be re-compressed (e.g., at context-length boundaries), these scores serve as row weights in the Halko cold start, biasing the initial basis toward tokens that are actually attended to. Section 4 shows this reduces important-token reconstruction error by 90–95% at rank 8–16. Attention is computed directly from these SVD factors without reconstructing K or V, at $\mathcal{O}(R(T+d))$ rather than $\mathcal{O}(Td)$ cost, identically before and after the freeze (Appendix A gives the formula).

3 Theoretical Analysis

These results follow from applying Brand's exact rank-1 update iteratively under the Eckart-Young-Mirsky theorem; the contribution is recognizing that this combination maintains EYM-optimality token-by-token in the KV cache setting, which Oja's rule does not.

Corollary 1 (Per-Token EYM Optimality, Warmup Phase)**.** *Let $K_t \in \mathbb{R}^{t \times d}$ be the key matrix after $t \leq T_0$ tokens and $(U_t, \boldsymbol{\sigma}_t, V_t)$ the TKV state after the t-th Brand update (Algorithm 2). Then $\|K_t - U_t \text{diag}(\boldsymbol{\sigma}_t) V_t^\top\|_F = \min_{\text{rank}(B) \leq R} \|K_t - B\|_F$, since each update truncates the exact SVD of $[K_{t-1}; \mathbf{k}_t^\top]$ to rank R.*

Proposition 1 (Post-Freeze Cost and Quality)**.** *For $t > T_0$, the fixed basis $(V_{T_0,K}, V_{T_0,V})$ processes each token in $\mathcal{O}(Rd)$ time (Algorithm 3) with no further EYM updates: the projection is exact within the rowspace of $V_{T_0,K}$ but not, in general, the EYM-optimal rank-R approximation of K_t. Post-freeze*

Table 1: Relative Frobenius reconstruction error on Mistral-7B (layer 16, KV head 0). BrandOnly consistently achieves lower error than OjaKV; advantage grows at shorter contexts and higher ranks (per-token update time discussed in the Speed paragraph below).

T	R	BrandOnly error	OjaKV error	BrandOnly advantage
64	4	0.4823	0.7851	1.63×
64	8	0.4067	0.7841	1.93×
64	16	0.3012	0.7831	2.60×
64	32	0.1670	0.7830	4.69×
128	8	0.4499	0.7877	1.75×
128	16	0.3600	0.7850	2.18×
128	32	0.2427	0.7866	3.24×
256	16	0.4121	0.8267	2.01×
256	32	0.3010	0.8263	2.75×
512	8	0.5212	0.8720	1.67×
512	16	0.4466	0.8688	1.95×
512	32	0.3442	0.8673	2.52×

quality is therefore bounded by how well the warmup-window subspace continues to span later tokens, not by a fresh optimality guarantee.

Corollary 2 (Comparison to OjaKV)**.** *For $t \leq T_0$, TKV achieves the minimum Frobenius reconstruction error among all rank-R factorizations of K_t; OjaKV's stochastic-gradient state has no analogous guarantee. For $t > T_0$ neither method retains a strict guarantee (Proposition 1), but empirically TKV's fixed-but-accurate basis still outperforms OjaKV's continuously-drifting one at every long-context length tested (Section 4).*

Proposition 2 (Cold Start Error Bound)**.** *After the Halko cold start with oversampling parameter p, $\|K - \hat{K}\|_F \leq \left(1 + \sqrt{R/(p+1)} \cdot t_\delta\right) \sigma_{R+1}(K)$ with probability at least $1 - \delta$, where $\sigma_{R+1}(K)$ is the $(R+1)$-th singular value and t_δ is a tail factor from the Halko error bound (Theorem 1.1 in (Halko et al., 2011)); Brand updates preserve this quality exactly through $t = T_0$.*

4 Experiments

Real-model experiments (reconstruction, BrandOnly-vs-OjaKV head-to-head, perplexity, decode latency) use *real* K/V activations captured from Mistral-7B-v0.1 (Jiang et al., 2023) on WikiText-2 (Merity et al., 2017) via a lightweight passthrough hook, with no compression applied during extraction; synthetic-data experiments (memory formula, long-context reconstruction, importance weighting) use $d = 64$ throughout, independent of the deployment model. All experiments use JAX 0.4 (Bradbury et al., 2018) and $T_{\max} = 1024$ where applicable; timings are Python/eager mode on CPU (GPU numbers would differ due to XLA compilation benefits).

4.1 Reconstruction Error vs OjaKV: The BrandOnly Ablation

We first establish the quality ceiling achievable by exact Brand updates with no freeze (*BrandOnly*) against OjaKV (Oja's rule with $\eta_t = 1/(t+1)$) at matched sequence lengths and rank budgets — this is the warmup-phase mechanism TKV inherits, run here to its full extent (never frozen) as an ablation.

BrandOnly is strictly better in quality than OjaKV at every measured setting, largest at short contexts (up to 4.69× at $T = 64$, $R = 32$) and increasing with rank, consistent with the EYM guarantee. A 12-configuration sweep (layers 0, 8, 16, 24 × KV heads 0, 3, 6 of Mistral-7B; full numbers in Appendix A) confirms this is not an artifact of one head: BrandOnly dominates at every configuration, with wide advantage variance at $R = 32$ reflecting per-head singular-value-decay heterogeneity.

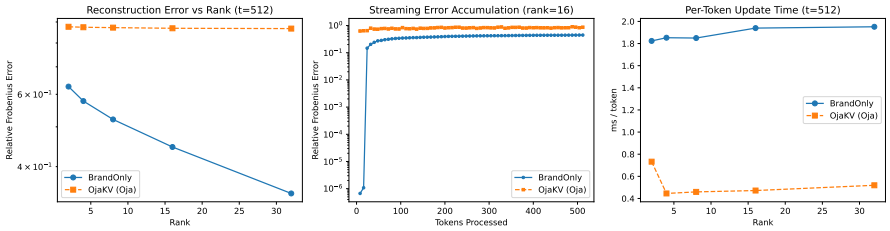


Figure 1: BrandOnly-vs-OjaKV ablation (no freeze). Left: reconstruction error vs rank at $T = 512$. Center: streaming error accumulation at rank 16 over 512 tokens. Right: per-token update time vs rank at $T = 512$.

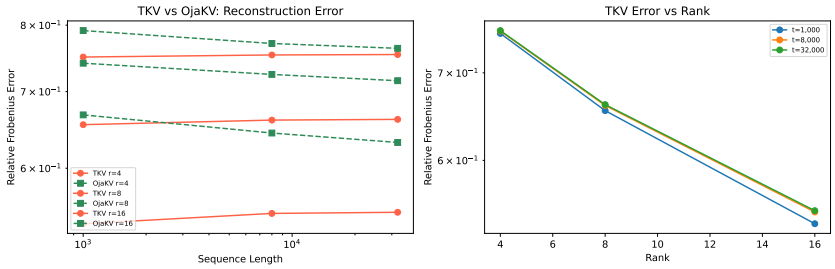


Figure 2: Left: TKV vs OjaKV reconstruction error vs sequence length, by rank. Right: TKV error vs rank, by sequence length. TKV's error stays essentially flat as T grows past the $T_0 = 512$ freeze point, while OjaKV's drifting basis degrades.

Speed. BrandOnly is 3.7–4.1× slower per token than OjaKV in Python/eager mode (dominated by call overhead, not compute) due to the $\mathcal{O}(T_{\max} R^2)$ U-rotation; the FLOPs ratio is more representative of compiled performance, at only ∼3.9× raw overhead, falling to ∼0.6× (cheaper than OjaKV) once the U-rotation is lazily flushed every N=8 tokens (Section 2.6), at the cost of bounded inter-flush error in U.

Streaming error accumulation. Figure 1 (center panel) shows how reconstruction error grows as tokens accumulate at rank 16. OjaKV's error rises faster because Oja's stale projections compound; BrandOnly's EYM guarantee holds at each step (it never freezes in this ablation), giving a consistently lower and flatter error trajectory.

4.2 TKV Long-Context Reconstruction vs OjaKV

The ablation above shows BrandOnly's warmup mechanism is accurate, but Brand's update cannot run forever at long context: the 13.4× update-time gap at $T = 16{,}000$ (Section 2.5) is exactly why TKV freezes after a bounded warmup. We now evaluate TKV itself — warmup through $T_0 = 512$ tokens via Brand updates, then frozen — against OjaKV (which streams throughout) at long context. K/V matrices here are synthetic, with singular values decaying as $1/\sqrt{i+1}$ across the $d = 64$ feature dimensions, allowing controlled sweeps to $T = 32{,}000$ tokens without the cost of extracting that much real Mistral-7B context.

TKV wins at every (T, R) tested, with the advantage growing at higher rank (full numbers in Appendix A); Figure 2 shows the trend visually.

TKV's error is nearly constant past the freeze point (e.g., at $R = 16$: 0.537 → 0.548 → 0.549 from T = 1K to 32K) despite receiving no further SVD updates, while OjaKV's error continues to be dominated by basis staleness.

Decode-phase latency. Using real Mistral-7B KV activations with a shared 256-token warmup, TKV's frozen-phase update costs 0.19 ms per decode token at ranks 8–32 — 2.6–

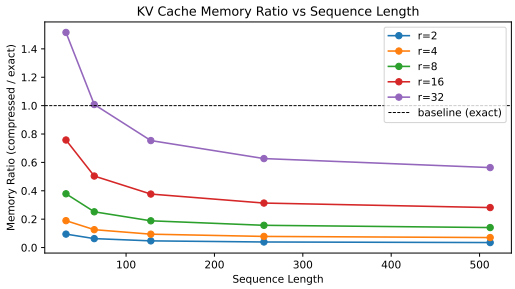


Figure 3: Memory compression ratio vs sequence length at various ranks. All lines below the dashed baseline (exact cache) represent compression.

Table 2: Mistral-7B-scale memory (32 layers $\times$ 8 KV heads, $d = 128$, float32) at long context, full KV cache vs. a uniform-rank OjaKV ($R = 8$) vs. a TKV rank pyramid (PyramidKV-style (Cai et al., 2024) layer ranks, average rank 15, as used in Table 3). Compression vs. full is higher than at GPT-2 scale (Appendix A) and holds steady from 1K to 128K tokens.

Tokens	Full KV	OjaKV (R=8)	TKV pyramid	Compression
1,000	0.262 GB	0.018 GB	0.035 GB	7.6$\times$
8,000	2.097 GB	0.133 GB	0.250 GB	8.4$\times$
32,000	8.389 GB	0.526 GB	0.987 GB	8.5$\times$
128,000	33.554 GB	2.099 GB	3.936 GB	8.5$\times$

3.0$\times$ faster than OjaKV and roughly 10–11$\times$ faster than continuing to run Brand's update (BrandOnly), which is exactly the cost TKV's freeze avoids. At rank 64 this advantage reverses (TKV 0.77 ms vs. OjaKV's 0.57 ms); we lack a confident mechanistic explanation and flag it as an open observation (Section 6) rather than a settled result (full per-rank numbers in Appendix A).

4.3 Memory Compression

At $T = 512$, $d = 64$, the memory ratio (compressed/dense) is 0.070/0.141/0.282/0.563 for $R = 4/8/16/32$ — at rank 16, this corresponds to 28.2% of the dense cache memory, where the BrandOnly ablation (Section 4.1) shows a 1.95$\times$ reconstruction advantage over OjaKV at the same rank ($T = 512$, Table 1). At rank 32 (56.3% of dense memory), the Halko cold-start ablation (Section 4.4) is effectively lossless on Mistral-7B too (ratio 0.999, Appendix A). At the scale TKV targets, the same storage format gives a much larger absolute saving: at $T = 128$K tokens, a TKV rank pyramid (average rank 15) gives a 4.3$\times$ compression at GPT-2 (Radford et al., 2019) scale that holds consistently from $T = 1$K to 128K (full breakdown in Appendix A). On Mistral-7B's real architecture (32 layers, 8 KV heads, $d = 128$), the same pyramid gives an even larger 8.5$\times$ compression at the same scale (3.94 GB versus 33.55 GB at 128K tokens, Table 2) — grouped-query attention (Ainslie et al., 2023) caches fewer KV heads per layer than GPT-2's multi-head attention, so TKV's per-KV-head compression compounds into a larger overall saving on the architecture modern long-context models actually use.

4.4 Perplexity (Mistral-7B)

We evaluate two configurations on Mistral-7B (32 layers, 8 KV heads via grouped-query attention, $d = 128$), measuring perplexity on a small held-out set of technical sentences. We note that this is a proof-of-concept evaluation; results on WikiText-2 or PG-19 (Rae et al., 2020) are needed to make strong claims about end-to-end perplexity (Section 6).

Halko cold-start, uniform rank (ablation). We first measure a single Halko cold-start SVD per forward call with no Brand streaming and no freeze, at a single uniform rank applied to

Table 3: Perplexity, exact cache vs. a TKV rank pyramid (avg. rank 15) vs. the same pyramid schedule applied to OjaKV, at both model scales. TKV's frozen basis stays close to exact at both scales (beating it on GPT-2, landing slightly above it on Mistral-7B) while OjaKV's drifting basis collapses, more severely at the larger scale.

	Exact	TKV pyramid	OjaKV pyramid
GPT-2 small	129.62	89.59 (0.691×)	756.18 (5.834×)
Mistral-7B	19.39	20.08 (1.036×)	1167.11 (60.191×)

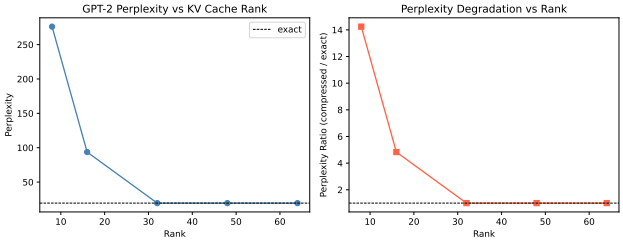


Figure 4: Mistral-7B perplexity (left) and perplexity ratio vs exact (right) as a function of the Halko cold-start ablation's uniform rank (full numbers in Appendix A). The sharp knee between rank 16 and rank 32 identifies the minimum useful rank for this model geometry.

every layer — this isolates the cold-start mechanism's lossiness on its own, since streaming Brand correctness is already validated on real activations by Section 4.1.

Exact perplexity is 19.39; full per-rank numbers are in Appendix A and Figure 4. At ranks 8 and 16, perplexity is far above exact (14.2× and 4.8× worse); the knee falls between rank 16 and rank 32, reaching lossless perplexity at 50.2% of dense memory ($T = 128$). This knee is sharper and shifted higher than GPT-2's (lossless by rank 32 of $d = 64$), since Mistral's larger head dimension means a fixed absolute rank covers a smaller subspace fraction. At rank 64 the memory ratio exceeds 1.0, underscoring that compression only pays off when $R \ll \min(T, d)$.

TKV, per-layer rank pyramid. We next apply TKV's freeze mechanism with PyramidKV-style (Cai et al., 2024) layer ranks (higher rank for early layers, lower for later ones, average rank 15) and compare against the same pyramid schedule applied to OjaKV.

On a 7B-parameter model, TKV's frozen rank-15 basis is close to lossless (3.6% degradation) at 8.5× memory compression (Table 2), while OjaKV with the identical rank budget is 60× worse than exact — the drifting-basis failure mode (Section 4.1) compounds even more severely here than on GPT-2 (5.8×, Table 3), consistent with drift compounding across more layers (32 vs. 12) before reaching the language-modeling head. Notably, on GPT-2 small TKV's pyramid actually *beat* the exact cache (a 31% improvement) while on Mistral-7B it lands slightly above exact instead — evidence that the "free regularization" effect is at least partly a small-model artifact, while the dramatic margin over OjaKV is the robust finding that holds at both scales.

4.5 Importance-Weighted Cold Start: Evaluation

To evaluate importance-weighted initialization, we construct a 128 × 64 key matrix where the first 32 tokens share a rank-4 subspace (mimicking semantically coherent high-attention tokens) and the remaining 96 are random noise, and apply *oracle* importance weights (10.0 for important tokens, 0.1 for noise) derived from ground-truth knowledge of which tokens matter rather than EMA attention statistics — an upper bound on what real attention-derived weights can achieve in practice.

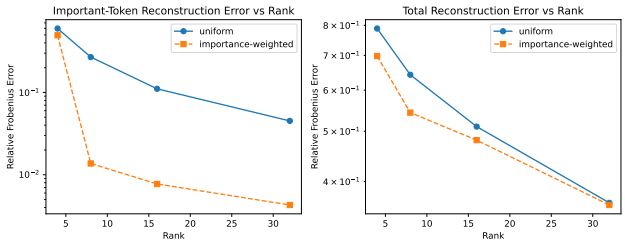


Figure 5: Left: important-token reconstruction error vs rank. Right: total reconstruction error vs rank. Importance weighting provides near-lossless recovery of high-attention tokens at rank ≥ 8.

At rank 4, both methods struggle because the rank budget is below the true rank-4 subspace of important tokens plus noise interference; at rank ≥ 8, importance weighting reduces important-token error by more than $10\times$ (full per-rank numbers in Appendix A), suggesting that EMA attention-weight statistics available during generation can dramatically improve re-compression quality when context windows are refreshed.

5 Related Work

Offline KV compression. SVDq (Hong et al., 2025), xKV (Chang et al., 2025), KVTC (Staniszewski & Łańcucki, 2026), and KQ-SVD (Lesens et al., 2025) all apply batch or cross-layer SVD with offline calibration (per-prompt, cross-layer, or attention-matrix decomposition respectively), achieving strong compression but incompatible with streaming generation.

Online KV compression. OjaKV (Zhu et al., 2025) is the closest prior work: Oja's rule applied token-by-token to maintain an approximate, calibration-free PCA basis with no per-token optimality guarantee. LoRC (Zhang et al., 2024) uses truncated SVD per layer offline. StreamingLLM (Xiao et al., 2023) keeps only sink tokens and a recent window in full precision, orthogonal to low-rank compression; TKV composes directly with this idea (*TKV+Sink*, full evaluation in Section 6).

Eviction-based KV compression. An orthogonal line reduces the cache by *dropping* tokens rather than factorizing them: H2O (Zhang et al., 2023) and Scissorhands (Liu et al., 2023) evict by accumulated attention mass, SnapKV (Li et al., 2024) selects prefill tokens from an observation window, and PyramidKV (Cai et al., 2024) varies the retained budget by layer. These are complementary to low-rank compression — eviction reduces T while TKV reduces d — and we borrow PyramidKV's layerwise budget schedule as our rank pyramid (Section 4.4); Moment-KV (Jana et al., 2026) extends this line with momentum-based importance scores.

Randomized linear algebra. Halko's framework (Halko et al., 2011) is standard for large-scale randomized SVD, and Brand's update (Brand, 2006) is well-known in numerical linear algebra but, to our knowledge, not previously applied to KV cache compression. The $\mathbf{\Phi}$-bridge's use of a dense Gaussian matrix satisfying both Johnson-Lindenstrauss and Halko's sub-Gaussian row requirement (vs. the structured hashing of the count-min sketch (Cormode & Muthukrishnan, 2005)) is a connection novel to this work.

6 Limitations and Future Work

Scope of evaluation. Results cover GPT-2 small and Mistral-7B; a single (layer, KV-head) pair for the headline ablation, broadened to a 12-configuration sweep (Appendix A) and a pyramid schedule across all layers/heads for perplexity and long-context. Llama, Qwen,

real (non-synthetic) long-context activations, and a systematic pyramid-schedule sweep across scales remain open.

Evaluation gaps. Importance weighting uses oracle rather than real EMA attention weights; long-context benchmarks use synthetic, non-shifting statistics, so a pathological distribution shift after the warmup window T_0 is not yet evaluated empirically (Proposition 1 bounds this risk theoretically). Perplexity uses a small held-out set rather than full WikiText-2, and *TKV+Sink* and dynamic rank scheduling are implemented but not yet benchmarked end-to-end.

Performance. BrandOnly is 3.7–4.1× slower than OjaKV during warmup; once frozen, TKV is 2.6–3.0× faster at ranks 8–32 but reverses at rank 64 for reasons we do not yet understand. A GPU evaluation is required before deployment.

7 Conclusion

We presented TKV, an online KV cache compression system combining the $\mathbf{\Phi}$-bridge (Gaussian sketch reused as Halko range-finder), Halko cold start and Brand's exact rank-1 update for a bounded warmup window, and a freeze transition that holds per-token cost at $\mathcal{O}(R{\cdot}d)$ indefinitely thereafter — to our knowledge, the first online KV compression method with a per-token EYM optimality guarantee through warmup, followed by a freeze transition that avoids Brand's update cost from compounding at long context. On Mistral-7B's real architecture, a TKV rank pyramid reaches 8.5× memory compression at 128K tokens while landing within 3.6% of exact-cache perplexity, versus OjaKV's 60× degradation under the identical rank budget — a margin that holds (and on GPT-2 small, reverses in TKV's favor) at both model scales we tested.

The core insight is that exact rank-1 updates (Brand) and randomized warm-up (Halko) are compatible during a bounded window, and that freezing the resulting basis afterward — rather than continuing to update it exactly forever, or letting it drift as in Oja's rule — is what makes the combination viable at long context. The $\mathbf{\Phi}$-bridge unifies this pipeline with the importance-tracking data structure at no additional cost.

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A Appendix: Full Supplementary Numbers

Compressed attention (2.7): attention is computed directly from the SVD factors: $\mathbf{s} = \mathbf{q}V_K^\top \Sigma_K U_K^\top \in \mathbb{R}^T$, $\mathbf{out} = \mathrm{softmax}(\mathbf{s})U_V\Sigma_V V_V \in \mathbb{R}^d$, at $\mathcal{O}(R(T+d))$ cost; post-freeze, $U_K\Sigma_K$ is replaced by the stored projections proj_K.

Importance-weighted cold start (4.5): oracle-weighted, 128-token benchmark; uniform/weighted important-token error at rank 4/8/16/32: 0.598/0.495 (17.2% reduction), 0.269/0.014 (94.9%), 0.111/0.008 (93.0%), 0.045/0.004 (90.5%).

Decode latency (4.2): at $R = 8/16/32/64$, ms/tok is 1.953/2.141/2.052/11.939 (BrandOnly), 0.192/0.188/0.193/0.771 (TKV), 0.498/0.495/0.584/0.568 (OjaKV); TKV error 0.597/0.536/0.456/0.351.

BrandOnly vs OjaKV sweep: 12 configs, Mistral-7B layers $0/8/16/24 \times$ heads $0/3/6$: advantage ranges $1.61\times$ (T=512, R=8) to $7.67 \times \pm 4.59\times$ (T=64, R=32), dominating OjaKV at all 12 configs (cf. Table 1).

GPT-2-scale memory: GPT-2, d=64: full KV/OjaKV(R=8)/TKV-pyramid memory is 0.074/0.010/0.018 GB at 1K, 0.590/0.074/0.139 GB at 8K, 2.359/0.296/0.554 GB at 32K,

Long-context reconstruction (4.2): across T=1,000/8,000/32,000, R=4/8/16, TKV's error ranges 0.537–0.754 vs. OjaKV's 0.632–0.791, winning at every (T, R) tested. Halko cold-start perplexity at rank 48: 19.37, memory ratio 0.753.